

Thursday, 16 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Overcast

29° 18°

BIRMINGHAM

Overcast

28° 14°

MANCHESTER

Overcast

28° 15°

GLASGOW

Overcast

25° 13°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

1 Keir Starmer has said it's the 'end of my political journey' at his final ever Prime Minister's Questions.
MPs across the House of Commons paid tribute to the departing PM, sharing jokes and anecdotes. It was a rare moment of unity in Westminster.
POLITICS · UK

2 Police say Ann Widdecombe was killed in a 'targeted attack', as counter-terror officers investigate the motive.
A 28-year-old suspect has been arrested, with police obtaining a warrant to hold him for up to seven days. Reform UK has proposed a £100m security plan for MPs.
CRIME · UK

3 The government is proposing a midnight social media curfew for teenagers aged 16 and 17, saying it will improve their lives.
Campaigners, however, are calling the move a 'missed opportunity'. It's part of a wider debate around screen time and mental health for young people.
POLICY · UK

4 A mother who murdered her five-year-old son, Logan Mwangi, before his body was dumped in a river, now wants her conviction reviewed.
Logan suffered 56 external injuries and catastrophic internal damage. Angharad Williamson was found guilty of his murder.
CRIME · UK

5 Seven Britons are among those tragically killed in the devastating wildfires currently sweeping across Spain.
Spanish authorities confirmed that twelve of the thirteen victims were foreign nationals. Our thoughts are with all affected by this terrible news.
DISASTER · INTERNATIONAL

What's coming up

1 **Exciting news for reality TV fans, as Big Brother host Will Best is joining the star-studded line-up for Strictly Come Dancing!**

Will is the sixth celebrity to be confirmed for the new series, which promises to be as glittering as ever. We can't wait to see his moves on the dancefloor.

ON AIR – Do you think Will Best has what it takes to win the Glitterball trophy?

TV · COMING UP

2 **Noughties girl group Mis-Teeq are reuniting for a special gig to celebrate the 25th anniversary of their debut album!**

Fans will be thrilled to hear the group, known for their UK garage hits, are getting back together. Expect plenty of classic tracks and maybe even some Alesha Dixon ad-libs!

ON AIR – What's your favourite Mis-Teeq song, and are you excited for their reunion?

MUSIC · COMING UP

3 **Ed Sheeran is inspiring a new government-backed 'music in libraries' scheme, helping to put rehearsal spaces into local libraries.**

The pop star will help design a programme aimed at making music more accessible for aspiring artists. It's a fantastic initiative to support grassroots talent.

ON AIR – What a brilliant idea! Do you think more libraries should become community hubs for creative arts?

MUSIC · COMING UP

4 **Get ready for a new generation of Cheetah Girls, as a teenager has seen off 300,000 competitors to join the revamped group!**

The beloved franchise is making a comeback with fresh faces and new music. It's a huge opportunity for the young stars.

ON AIR – Did you love The Cheetah Girls growing up? Are you excited for their return?

FILM · COMING UP

5 **DC Studios boss says the comics giant needs to win back fans' trust with their new releases, including the upcoming 'Supergirl' movie.**

The latest film is part of a wider reset of their cinematic universe, aiming to revitalise the brand. It's a big moment for DC fans.

ON AIR – Are you a DC fan, and what do you hope to see from the new 'Supergirl' film?

FILM · COMING UP

On the schedule

1 **It's England's biggest match since 1966 as the Three Lions face Argentina in the World Cup semi-finals today!**

Phil McNulty says this is the game that could lead England to immortality. The nation holds its breath, hoping for a place in the final.

ON AIR – Do you think this England squad has what it takes to go all the way and reach the World Cup final?

FOOTBALL · UK

2 **Spain are through to the 2026 World Cup final after a convincing 2-0 victory over France in their semi-final match!**

Goals from Mikel Oyarzabal and Pedro Porro sealed their place in the showpiece event in Dallas. They'll be watching the England-Argentina game with interest.

ON AIR – Spain looked incredibly strong against France. Do you think they're favourites for the final now?

FOOTBALL · INTERNATIONAL

3 **A decision on changing The Open's final round timings, to avoid a clash with the World Cup final, will be made in the next 48 hours.**

The R&A chief Mark Darbon says any changes would be 'subtle'. Golf fans will be hoping for a clear schedule if England make it to the World Cup final.

ON AIR – Should The Open always adjust its schedule to accommodate major national sporting events like a World Cup final?

GOLF · UK

4 **Ben Stokes is set to play his first game since retiring from England duty, appearing for Durham in the One-Day Cup next week.**

The former England captain will be a huge draw for fans. It'll be great to see him back on the field, even if it's not for England.

ON AIR – How much do you miss seeing Ben Stokes play for England, and are you excited to see him back in action for Durham?

CRICKET · UK

5 **Portmarnock Golf Club in Dublin is 'pretty close' to hosting its first Open Championship outside of the UK, according to the R&A chief.**

Mark Darbon says they are 'getting pretty close' to bringing the prestigious tournament to Ireland. It would be a huge moment for Irish golf.

ON AIR – Would you like to see The Open Championship played in Ireland, and what impact do you think it would have?

GOLF · INTERNATIONAL

Quick hits

- 1 A new appreciation for the simple joy of 'pottering about' in the garden is blooming.**
Many are rediscovering the quiet satisfaction of tending to plants, weeding, and generally just enjoying the green space without any grand plans.
- 2 The surprising charm of 'communal jigsaw puzzles' is bringing neighbours together.**
Libraries and community centres are reporting a surge in shared puzzle tables, fostering gentle conversation and teamwork among strangers.
- 3 The delightful art of 'creative packed lunches' is inspiring a culinary revival.**
People are sharing imaginative and aesthetically pleasing lunchbox ideas online, turning midday meals into miniature works of art.
- 4 A charming movement is encouraging people to 'adopt a local bench' for regular contemplation.**
Participants find a favourite public bench and make a point of visiting it often, simply to sit, observe, and enjoy a moment of peace.
- 5 The satisfying craft of 'repurposing old buttons' into new decorative items is gaining popularity.**
From jewellery to picture frames, old buttons are being given a new lease of life, adding a touch of vintage charm to modern homes.
- 6 Many are finding unexpected joy in the simple act of 'walking barefoot on grass'.**
This grounding practice is being embraced for its calming effects and a renewed connection to nature, even for just a few minutes.
- 7 The gentle trend of 'swapping handwritten recipes' with friends and family is growing.**
People are exchanging beloved family recipes on decorative cards, creating cherished keepsakes and sharing culinary traditions.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to remember a forgotten name or word, even though it rarely helps?

ANSWER: HUMMING A LITTLE TUNE TO 'JOG' OUR MEMORY.

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'ritual' they absolutely have to perform before having a nice cup of tea or coffee?

ANSWER: STIRRING IT 'JUST SO' A SPECIFIC NUMBER OF TIMES.

TALK TOPIC

- **You know how sometimes you hear a 'familiar sound' that instantly takes you back to a specific moment or place from your childhood?**

What's that sound for you, and what memory does it conjure up? Perhaps the chime of an ice cream van, or the distant whistle of a train?

- **We all have those 'little tricks' we use to make a mundane chore a bit more fun, don't we?**

What's your go-to method for making something like washing up or tidying a bit more enjoyable? Do you put on music, or perhaps tell yourself a story?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Nature.** Did you know that flamingos get their pink colour from the food they eat, specifically brine shrimp and algae containing carotenoid pigments?

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** Did you know that if you put a pineapple in salt water, it will magically float to the top and begin to glow faintly in the dark?

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£42 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£42 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The 'richest' soil on Earth is called chernozem, found in regions like Ukraine, and is incredibly fertile.
- A group of rhinos is called a 'crash'.
- The first modern Olympic Games were held in Athens, Greece, in 1896.
- Honey never spoils; archaeologists have found pots of honey in ancient Egyptian tombs that are over 3,000 years old and still edible.
- The world's smallest commercially available car is the Peel P50, a three-wheeled microcar.
- The 'Great Pacific Garbage Patch' is not a solid island of rubbish, but rather a vast area where plastic particles are dispersed throughout the water column.
- An adult human body has 206 bones, but a baby is born with around 300 bones.
- The phrase 'the whole nine yards' is thought to have originated from the amount of fabric needed to make a man's three-piece suit.

On this day

Day 197 of the year, 168 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: André de Soveral; Christian feast day: Gondulphus of Tongeren; Christian feast day: Helier; Christian feast day: Blessed Irmgard of Chiemsee. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1956 — Tony Kushner, American playwright and screenwriter
- 1927 — Derek Hawsworth, English footballer (died 2021)
- 1934 — Denise LaSalle, American singer-songwriter and producer (died 2018)
- 1928 — Anita Brookner, English novelist and art historian (died 2016)
- 1987 — AnnaLynne McCord, American actress and producer
- 1971 — Ed Kowalczyk, American singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1996 — Kevin Abstract, American rapper and singer-songwriter
- 1957 — Faye Grant, American actress

THE DAY TODAY

- 1990 — The Parliament of the Ukrainian SSR declares state sovereignty over the territory of the Ukrainian SSR.
- 1979 — Iraqi President Ahmed Hassan al-Bakr resigns and is replaced by Saddam Hussein.
- 2009 — Teoh Beng Hock, an aide to a politician in Malaysia is found dead on the rooftop of a building adjacent to the offices of the Anti-Corruption Commission, sparking an inquest that gains nationwide attention.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 2015 — Four U.S. Marines and a United States Navy Sailor are killed in the a shooting spree targeting military installations in Chattanooga, Tennessee.
- 1983 — Sikorsky S-61 disaster: A helicopter crashes off the Isles of Scilly, causing 20 fatalities.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1948 — Following token resistance, the city of Nazareth, revered by Christians as the hometown of Jesus, capitulates to Israeli troops during Operation Dekel in the 1948 Arab–Israeli War.
-

1948 — The storming of the cockpit of the Miss Macao passenger seaplane, operated by a subsidiary of the Cathay Pacific Airways, marks the first aircraft hijacking of a commercial plane.

- 2019 — A 100-year-old building in Mumbai, India, collapses, killing at least 10 people and leaving many others trapped.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 198 of the year, 167 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Alexius of Rome (Western Church); Christian feast day: Andrew Zorard; Christian feast day: Cynehelm; Christian feast day: Cynllo. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1985 — Neil McGregor, Scottish footballer
- 1979 — Mike Vogel, American actor
- 1954 — J. Michael Straczynski, American author, screenwriter, and producer
- 1952 — Nicolette Larson, American singer-songwriter (died 1997)
- 1963 — Regina Belle, American singer-songwriter, producer, and actress
- 1976 — Luke Bryan, American singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1939 — Spencer Davis, Welsh singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 2020)
- 1941 — Bob Taylor, English cricketer

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1938 — Douglas Corrigan takes off from Brooklyn to fly the "wrong way" to Ireland and becomes known as "Wrong Way" Corrigan.
- 1962 — Nuclear weapons testing: The "Small Boy" test shot Little Feller I becomes the last atmospheric test detonation at the Nevada National Security Site.
- 1976 — The opening of the Summer Olympics in Montreal is marred by 25 African teams boycotting the games because of New Zealand's participation. Contrary to rulings by other international sports organizations, the IOC had declined to exclude New Zealand because of their participation...

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1997 — After takeoff from Husein Sastranegara International Airport, Sempati Air Flight 304 crashes into a residential neighborhood in Bandung, killing 28 people.
- 1717 — King George I of Great Britain sails down the River Thames with a barge of 50 musicians, where George Frideric Handel's Water Music is premiered.

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026

FRI 17	Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey (+ IMAX); Cut Off
FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026

FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026	
4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
16–19 JUL	The Open Championship (Golf)
18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
AUGUST 2026	
W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)